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RE V1 V2 V3 V4



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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 2, 2025 • \$6

U.S. strikes not bound by war law, DOJ argues

Approval isn't needed to continue alleged cartel attacks, Congress is told

BY ELLEN NAKASHIMA
AND NOAH ROBERTSON

A top Justice Department lawyer has told lawmakers that the Trump administration can continue its lethal strikes against alleged drug traffickers in Latin America — and is not bound by a decades-old law requiring Congress to give approval for ongoing hostilities.

T. Elliot Gaiser, head of the Trump administration's Office of Legal Counsel, made his remarks to a small group of lawmakers last week amid signs that the president may be planning to escalate the military campaign in the region, including potentially hitting targets within Venezuela.

The president needs lawmakers' approval for sustained military action under the 1973 War Powers Resolution, which was passed in the wake of the Vietnam War to prevent another drawn-out, undeclared conflict.

A 60-day clock started ticking after the administration informed Congress on Sept. 4 that it had conducted a strike on an alleged drug boat in the Caribbean two days earlier. It has followed that with other strikes and has killed dozens of people.

The 60-day window closes Monday, and until now it had been

SEE **STRIKES** ON **A10**

Preparations: Venezuelans worry more about food than attack. **A14**

U.S. military buildup: See charts of planes, ships off Venezuela. **A16**

Walmart, Amazon steer in AI, pare back workers

BY DANIELLE ABRIL

Amazon and Walmart, the nation's two largest private employers, swelled with hundreds of thousands of new workers in recent years as they battled for larger slices of consumer pocketbooks. Amazon said in 2021 that its workforce had grown to more than 1.6 million people and boasted of being “the largest job-creator in the U.S.” Walmart said last year that plans for 150 new stores would create jobs across the United States.

Now the retail giants are changing tack, laying off workers or keeping headcount flat as they pledge to become leaner businesses where artificial intelligence does more of the work.

Amazon said last week it would cut 14,000 corporate jobs and saw its stock jump after reporting that sales grew 13 percent in the most recent quarter compared with last year, to \$180 billion. (Amazon founder Jeff Bezos owns The Washington Post.)

Walmart CEO Doug McMillon warned at a company event in September that AI is set “to change literally every job” and

SEE **JOBS** ON **A5**

Jobs emerge, too: AI has led firms to create and adapt positions. **B11**

Survivors who fled the recently captured city of El Fashir accuse RSF paramilitary and its allies of mass ethnic killings, hostage taking



AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A brutal purge in Sudan's war

NAIROBI — Families gunned down as they huddled for safety. Young children weeping over their mother's body in the desert. Doctors seized for ransom and executed.

Such are the stories trickling out of El Fashir, the Sudanese city conquered by the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces last Sunday. The vast majority of people inside the city are still unreachable; only a few traumatized people have been able to escape and testify to the horrors unfolding there.

Sudan's civil war, which erupted in 2023 after a power struggle between the head of the RSF and the army chief, has become a sprawling conflagration, sucking in global and regional powers and leaving much of the country in ruins. The RSF is backed by the United Arab Emirates; Sudan's army has received weapons from Iran, Turkey and Russia.

Now, a war that has already claimed hundreds of thousands of lives has entered one of its darkest chapters. The Washington Post interviewed nine civilians, doctors, aid workers and combatants in and around El Fashir,

BY KATHARINE
HOURELD
AND HAFIZ
HAROUN

A woman rests in Tewila, in Sudan's war-torn Darfur region, on Tuesday after fleeing El Fashir in the wake of the city's fall.

who described a frenzied and indiscriminate campaign of ethnic killings and hostage taking by the RSF and allied fighters.

As international outrage mounts, even the head of the RSF, Gen. Mohamed Hamdan Dagalo, commonly known as Hemedti, has admitted to abuses by his forces. On Thursday, the group released a video showing the arrest of one of its commanders, who was filmed taunting and executing large groups of civilians.

The United States has already sanctioned Hemedti and other RSF leaders, as well as top figures in the Sudanese military (SAF), which has also been accused of war crimes. On Thursday, a bipartisan group of U.S. senators urged the American government to go further in light of what they called “the genocide in Darfur.”

“The RSF's long-predicted ethnically targeted assault on the civilian population of El-Fasher makes clear that the United States must consider the designation of the RSF as a

SEE **SUDAN** ON **A19**

At protests, tear gas injures, sickens and tests law

DHS says violence necessitates its use, but tactics are scrutinized

BY MARIANNE LEVINE
AND ROBERT KLEMKO

Federal immigration officers are using chemical irritants to disperse protesters in ways that violate American policing norms and are testing the boundaries of use-of-force laws, video footage from Chicago shows, in some cases hitting demonstrators directly with the munitions.

Border Patrol and Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers have deployed tear gas in cities around the country, but its use has been especially prevalent in Chicago, where the Trump administration launched “Operation Midway Blitz” in September as part of the president's crack-down on illegal immigration.

Since then, federal officers have thrown chemical agents out of vehicles on city streets, creat-

SEE **TEAR GAS** ON **A8**



JOSHUA LOTT/THE WASHINGTON POST

A federal agent kicks a tear-gas canister during a recent clash with residents and protesters in Chicago.

Trump has gone too far, most say

POLL REGISTERS BROAD DISAPPROVAL

But voters evenly split on parties as midterms loom

BY SCOTT CLEMENT,
DAN BALZ
AND ANDREW BA TRAN

Americans broadly disapprove of how President Donald Trump is handling his job, and a majority say he has gone too far in exercising the powers of his office, according to a Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos poll. But a year out from the 2026 midterm elections, there is little evidence that negative impressions of Trump's performance have accrued to the benefit of the Democratic Party, with voters split almost evenly in their support for Democrats and Republicans.

Overall, 41 percent of Americans say they approve of the job Trump is doing, while 59 percent disapprove. That level of disapproval is the highest in a Post-ABC poll since January 2021, a week after the attack on the Capitol. Trump's support among self-identified Republicans remains strong at 86 percent, while 95 percent of Democrats disapprove. Among independents, Trump's approval rating is 30 percent, while his disapproval mark is 69 percent.

Across eight issues that include the economy, immigration, tariffs,

SEE **POLL** ON **A6**

@PKCapitol: Governor races show might of Democrats' 2018 class. **A2**

With food aid in limbo, rush underway to fill SNAP gap

BY REIS THEBAULT
AND MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

Mayors and governors from San Francisco to Virginia will cover millions of dollars in missing federal assistance to feed their most vulnerable residents as the Trump administration battles orders from two federal judges to release backup funds.

The desperate dash to replace money from the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, known as SNAP, is unfolding in both red states and blue states as funding for the program that feeds 42 million Americans — most of whom are children, elderly or disabled — ran out Saturday. Four weeks into the government shutdown, the Trump administration has so far declined to use billions in contingency funds to cover the shortfall.

On Friday, a Rhode Island federal judge said the Agriculture Department must distribute the contingency funds “as soon as possible.” Another federal judge in Massachusetts also directed the government to decide by Monday whether it would use

SEE **SNAP** ON **A7**

ACA price hikes: Who will be the worst hit as enrollment starts? **A4**

THE WORLD
Britain is making room for lawyers who want to forgo the white wig. **A11**

METRO
Early voting surges in Virginia, mostly among likely Democrats. **B18**



SPORTS
A soundtrack to the games of our lives: the best sports theme songs.

ARTS & STYLE
Iranian dissident director Jafar Panahi's latest is in the Oscars conversation.



BOOK WORLD
In “The Rose Field,” Philip Pullman's pretend world is like our real one.

DAYLIGHT SAVING TIME ENDS
Don't forget to set your clocks back one hour as standard time begins.

COMICS.....INSERT
OBITUARIES.....B21
OPINION PAGES.....A21
POLITICS & THE NATION.....A3

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